

## *Ukraine ceasefire talks unlikely through spring 2027*

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### 【メール原文】

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Ukraine

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Escalation likely precludes Russia-Ukraine ceasefire talks through spring 2027

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Despite the new US effort to restart negotiations, the probability of serious ceasefire talks remains very low at least through early 2027 (90% probability); real progress would require a substantive shift that softens both sides' positions (10% probability).

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Positions have hardened since the last round of talks, the sides share no common ground on substance or participation, and both are preparing to escalate the war over the next six months to improve their positions.

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Even the most optimistic scenario would likely produce agreement only on the format of negotiations.

A coming escalation of the war likely precludes serious talks, let alone a ceasefire. Both Russia and Ukraine have incentives to try to improve their battlefield positions in an escalatory period that is likely to last at least six months (see note [Escalation between Russia and Ukraine coming in the autumn](#) ). During that time, shuttle diplomacy will continue intermittently without making any progress (a 90% probability).

During the recent visit of US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner to Kyiv and Moscow, Russian President Vladimir Putin claimed successes advancing the front line, expressed confidence in achieving his goals, and returned to the language of the war's "root causes." In Kremlin terms, that means Ukrainian neutrality, limits on its military, and no path to NATO membership. Senior sources say Putin left the meeting with the US envoys still believing his army can take all of the Donetsk region within six months, though military analysts consulted by Eurasia Group view that as unrealistic.

Ukraine also remains skeptical about a renewed negotiations push. President Volodymyr Zelensky said the war would probably continue into another winter, and he was explicit that Ukraine would not give up territory under any circumstances.

The two sides are also diverging on what format talks should take. Russia wants to exclude Ukraine and Europe for as long as possible and use the APEC summit in Shenzhen in November for a trilateral meeting between Putin, US President Donald Trump, and Chinese President Xi Jinping. CIA Director John Ratcliffe, who visited Moscow a week before Witkoff and Kushner, raised the idea of a Trump-Putin-Zelensky trilateral, reviving a proposal the Kremlin has stalled for well over a year. Zelensky himself is ready to meet with Putin, but he wants that meeting to sit inside a broader US- and

Europe-backed process. Each side, in effect, is seeking a format it believes it can control.

Washington still has some levers over both sides. With Russia, the carrots are already on the table from last November's plan: sanctions relief, reinstatement into the G8, and a US stake in a frozen-assets investment fund. The sticks include a lower oil price cap, wider secondary tariffs on Russian crude buyers, and tighter sanctions on the shadow tanker fleet and its insurers. But each option carries a domestic cost in the form of higher gasoline prices that could dissuade aggressive use at a time when the Iran war is also increasing price pressures.

With Ukraine, the carrot is continued and expanded US weapons and intelligence support; the stick, used once in March 2025 and reportedly threatened again last November, is withholding both. However, Ukraine now produces roughly 40% of its own equipment, and European governments, led by France, say they can now cover most of Kyiv's intelligence needs themselves, though the US likely maintains an edge in imagery and technical collection.

Escalation and diplomacy will continue to move on parallel tracks. A reciprocal pause in strikes on Kyiv and Moscow held through the visit of the US envoys, but both sides expect renewed fighting. A push for negotiations could resume in late September, after Russia's Duma election and before the US midterms. Any talks are highly unlikely to produce a ceasefire or framework agreement. Instead, both sides will use the intermittent diplomatic process to manage domestic and Western opinion while continuing to seek advantage on the battlefield.

A narrow US-Russia-Ukraine trilateral format could yield limited technical agreements, such as prisoner exchanges, limits on strikes, and modest de-escalation steps, but little progress is likely on an actual ceasefire, territorial issues, security arrangements, or broader post-war related questions.

There is, however, a low probability path to a substantive shift and serious ceasefire talks (10% odds). That could follow a major Russian breakthrough on the battlefield, severe damage to Ukrainian infrastructure, similarly effective Ukrainian strikes against Russia, more forceful US pressure on Russia or Ukraine, or Zelensky's ouster.

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